

Significant changes from the 2010 Declaration of Principles are indicated in green.
Wording that has been reintroduced from the 1989 Declaration of Principles is in blue.

DRAFT REVISED Declaration of Principles
Concerning the Conduct of the Search for ExtraTerrestrial Intelligence (SETI)
(version: 1 Oct 2024)

The parties to this Declaration are individuals and institutions participating in the scientific Search for Extraterrestrial Intelligence (SETI), that is, the astronomy-based search for ‘technosignatures’¹ or evidence of past or present intelligent life and technology beyond Earth.

The purpose of this Declaration is to declare our commitment to conduct the Search for ExtraTerrestrial Intelligence in a scientifically rigorous manner; to establish uniform procedures for scientists to confirm putative evidence of an intelligent extraterrestrial civilisation; to provide guidance to the scientific community for the announcement of a confirmed SETI detection while balancing the community imperative of providing rapid and accurate information to a wide audience, with consideration for the safety and exposure of individual scientists involved; and to proactively inform the public of the procedures and guidelines that signatories will respect if a confirmed SETI detection occurs.

The commitments in this Declaration are made with the recognition that the scientific and communications landscapes are ever-changing, and this Declaration will be supplemented with Best Practices Guidelines and a Code of Conduct that will be periodically re-examined and updated. This Declaration and any supplemental Guidelines and Codes, together with a current list of signatory parties, will be placed on file with the International Academy of Astronautics (IAA) and made available on the IAA website.

Principles

1. Handling Candidate Evidence:

- In the event of a putative detection of extraterrestrial intelligence, the discoverer will make all efforts to verify the detection, using the resources available to the discoverer and in collaboration with other investigators. Such efforts will include, but not be limited to, observations at more than one facility and/or by more than one organisation.
- Information about candidate signals or other potential detections should be handled with the same care as provisional laboratory results, recognising that initial findings may be incomplete or ambiguous, requiring thorough analysis and confirmation, which could be a lengthy process. It is crucial to uphold the highest standards of scientific responsibility and integrity throughout this process. Additionally, best practices in science communication should be employed to clearly convey the importance and significance of candidate discoveries to non-specialist audiences.

2. Searching:

- SETI practitioners and their institutions and organisations will be free to present reports on activities and results in public and professional fora. Institutions and organisations should be responsive to news organisations, social media platforms, and other public communications media. Responses to inquiries should be prompt, accurate and honest.

¹ ‘Technosignatures’ are defined as observable evidence of technology utilised by advanced extraterrestrial civilisations e.g. narrow-band radio signals, laser emission, infrared excess associated with large-scale energy usage, anomalies in astronomical measurements due to megastructures etc. Unlike biosignatures, which point to biological processes, technosignatures would indicate the presence of intelligent life and focus on artificial or engineered phenomena that would directly reveal the existence of extraterrestrial civilisations. This Declaration is intended to apply to the search for intelligent extraterrestrial life, not extraterrestrial life in general, nor to unidentified anomalous phenomena (UAP) in the Earth’s atmosphere.

- There is no obligation to disclose verification efforts until a discovery is confirmed. If a candidate technosignature is discovered, communication about ongoing observations and analyses may be necessary to dispel rumours and provide accurate and reliable information.
- Speculative or unconfirmed conclusions should be clearly identified as such, and exaggerated statements should be avoided.
- Institutions and organisations should engage with news organisations to provide accurate and timely updates of their activities, ensuring proactive engagement with the public to provide a source for accurate information and consider other ways to explain a putative signal among public audiences.
- Individual practitioners should have the right to decline from engaging directly or continually with the media, including social media if they choose to do so, and shall use their best efforts to ensure that their organisation or institution provides updates on their science.

3. Confirmed Detections:

- If the verification process confirms – by the consensus of the other investigators involved and to a degree of certainty judged by the discoverers to be credible – that a signal or other evidence is due to extraterrestrial intelligence, the discoverer shall report this conclusion in a full, complete and open manner to the public, the scientific community, and the Secretary General of the United Nations.
- The confirmation report should include the basic data, the data analysis process and results of the verification efforts, any conclusions and interpretations, and any detected information content of the signal itself. A formal report will also be made to the International Academy of Astronautics, the International Astronomical Union Central Bureau for Astronomical Telegrams, the United Nations Secretary General, the Committee on Space Research (COSPAR) of the International Science Council, the International Institute of Space Law, and the International Telecommunications Union.

4. Data Accessibility:

- All data necessary for the confirmation of the detection to be replicated should be made available to the international scientific community through publications, meetings, conferences, official websites, and other appropriate means.

5. Monitoring and Archiving:

- The discovery should be monitored and best practices for the safe, reliable and resilient handling of data should be employed. Any and all data bearing on the evidence of extraterrestrial intelligence should be recorded and stored permanently to the greatest extent feasible and practicable, in a form that will make it available to observers and to the scientific community for replication of results and further analysis.

6. Data and Frequency Protection:

- If the evidence of detection is in the form of electromagnetic signals, observers should seek international agreement to protect the appropriate frequencies by exercising the extraordinary procedures established within the International Telecommunication Union. Evidence in a form other than electromagnetic signals should be protected utilising best scientific practices.

7. Post-Detection Protocol:

- The IAA SETI Committee will appoint a Post-Detection Sub-Committee to assist in matters that may arise in the event of a confirmed signal, and to support the scientific and public analysis by offering guidance, interpretation, and discussion of the wider implications of the detection. This

sub-committee will be chaired by the chair of the IAA SETI Committee, and should include communications professionals.

- The SETI Committee Executive Officers will support and assist the Post-Detection Sub-Committee with engagements with social media platforms and news organisations to responsively and effectively assist in the dissemination of accurate and reliable information.
- The IAA SETI Committee will maintain and support working groups dedicated to Post-Detection issues, providing assistance during the discovery process, aiding in scientific analysis, and focusing on subjects such as best practices for public communication about technosignatures science. These working groups will actively collaborate with interdisciplinary researchers to explore the broader implications of potential discoveries.

8. Communications with ETI following a confirmed detection:

- Signatories to this Declaration will refrain from making any unilateral communications in response to a confirmed extraterrestrial signal, and shall cooperate with appropriate international consultations. These consultations should be conducted through a broadly representative international body, such as the United Nations. The specific procedures for such consultations will be outlined in a separate agreement, declaration, or arrangement to ensure a coordinated and responsible approach.²

9. Ethical and Legal Considerations:

- SETI practitioners shall adhere to the highest ethical standards, ensuring cooperation, honesty, and integrity in all aspects of their work. They will collaborate with international legal authorities to establish clear frameworks for managing the dissemination of information about potential extraterrestrial detections, ensuring compliance with relevant laws and regulations. SETI practitioners shall cooperate in establishing ethical standards for the handling of any putative and confirmed detected evidence of extraterrestrial intelligence.

This Declaration shall be open for signature by organisations and practitioners engaged or otherwise interested in SETI. These revised Protocols are intended to replace the previous document adopted by the International Academy of Astronautics SETI Committee in 2010.

² This Declaration is not addressed to the separate and distinct subject of messaging to extraterrestrial intelligence in advance of a confirmed detected extraterrestrial signal (METI).
